

The Punjab crisis since 1984: a reassessment

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Abstract

Over the last decade there has been increasing scholarly interest in the ethnic character of the Indian state. This interest has coincided with the rise of the Hindu revivalist Bharatiya Janata Party [BJP], nation-wide clashes between Hindus and Muslims, and bitter conflict over affirmative action for backward classes. Simultaneously, the Indian state has been confronted by regional movements in Kashmir, Assam and Punjab seeking secession from the Indian Union. By focusing on the Punjab crisis this article argues that conventional explanations have concentrated on national political centralization and regional economic factors, to the neglect of Sikh ethno-nationalism and its dialectical relationship with strategies for ethnic conflict management followed by the Indian state since 1947. Drawing on recent revisionist accounts, the Indian state, it is suggested, should be viewed as a form of an ethnic democracy in which hegemonic control is exercised over non-Hindu ethnic groups. The Punjab case-study shows that hegemonic control has characterized the relationship between the Sikhs and the Indian state between 1947 and 1984, and efforts to re-establish hegemonic control after 1984 degenerated into violent control. The experience of the last ten years suggests that hegemonic control and violent control are unlikely to provide an enduring solution to the Punjab crisis. Rather, there is a need to address fundamentally the crisis of the Indian political system and how it has managed its minorities since 1947. Central to this reassessment is the viability of India's majoritarian political system in the context of an ethnically plural society.

Keywords

India; Sikh, Punjab; ethnic; conflict; Hindu; hegemony.

Introduction

Over the last decade there has been an increasing scholarly interest in the ethnic character of the Indian state. This interest has coincided with the rise of the Hindu revivalist Bharatiya Janata Party [BJP], nation-wide clashes between Hindus and Muslims, and bitter conflict

over affirmative-action proposals for backward classes. Simultaneously, the Indian state has been confronted by regional movements in Kashmir, Assam and Punjab seeking secession from the India Union. Taken together, these developments provide a new point of departure for re-evaluating the ethnic nature of the Indian state. By focusing on the Punjab crisis since 1984, it is the contention of this article that conventional approaches to understanding the Punjab crisis have proved inadequate. Drawing on comparative work on ethnic conflict and the current revisionist reassessment of the Indian state, it will be argued that the Punjab crisis provides a case-study for a radical re-evaluation of the ethnic nature of the Indian state and understanding the Sikh agitation. The rest of the article is divided into three parts: (i) a brief critical summary of the conventional approaches to the Punjab crisis; (ii) an alternative perspective centred around the idea of India as an 'ethnic democracy' where some ethnic groups are managed through democratic 'hegemonic control' and, increasingly, strategies of 'violent control'; and (iii), a reassessment of developments in Punjab since 1984 in the context of the above debate.

Conventional approaches

In contrast to the events leading up to Operation Blue Star, the period since 1984 has received little scholarly attention. This lack of focus is all the more surprising given the profound implications of the last ten years for both Sikhs and the Indian state: the decade has witnessed the deaths of almost 30,000 people,¹ the quasi-militarization of Punjab, *de facto* police raj, and a sustained separatist movement which has systematically destabilized traditional Sikh politics. Recent claims by the Government of India [GOI] that the Punjab crisis has been resolved need to be treated with the same circumspection as similar statements over the last decade. In fact, the alienation of mainstream Sikh political organizations is much greater than at any time since 1984, having been effectively banned by policies of President's Rule (May 1987-February 1992) and now 'coercive politics' practised by the state's administration.

Conventional approaches to the Punjab crisis fall broadly into three schools of thought: the centralization thesis, economic, and Sikh ethno-nationalism. Before we proceed to outline our alternative perspective, we need to discuss briefly the nature and limitations of these approaches.

The centralization thesis

The main political science explanation put forward for the Punjab crisis (Brass 1991) is that it is an acute manifestation of the centralizing tendencies unleashed by the post-Nehruvian leadership. Whereas the

objective tendencies within Indian politics over the last two decades have been towards regionalism, pluralism and decentralization, the response of the national leadership to these pressures has been to centralize power in New Delhi. In most other states the growth of powerful political regionalism has been mediated by the political ascendancy of regional parties who have bargained with the centralizing pressures for leadership at the provincial level. In Punjab, however, the unstable political competition between the religiously exclusive Akali Dal and the Congress-I has frustrated such a development with the consequences that the latter's pursuit of regional and national power drove the Akali Dal, first, to agitational politics and, later, to the encouragement of militant violence. Although the Punjab crisis has developed a dynamic of its own – the psychological humiliation of Sikhs, retributive violence, and unyielding positions – the key to unlocking it lies primarily in restructuring centre-state relations (Brass 1991, pp. 212–13).

There are four basic limitations of the centralization thesis. First, it does not satisfactorily explain why the centralization drive should have *disproportionately* adverse consequences for India's religious minorities, especially a minority like the Sikhs who are so effectively integrated into the state structure. Second, the differences in the centralization drives of Nehruvian and post-Nehruvian leadership were one of degree rather than kind. A more critical reading of the Nehruvian era in Punjab politics (Pettigrew 1975, pp. 105–24) would reveal, even by the set of objective criteria, the high degree of 'bossism', constitutional subversion, and authoritarian rule. Third, decentralization as a strategy for containing separatist force would, paradoxically, require further centralization lest the forces that have supported separatism/autonomy make the latter untenable.² Fourth, few scholars of this school (Bombwall 1986) seem to have recognized that underpinning the Sikh demands is a parallel claim to sovereignty which would be difficult to accommodate within Indian federalism. If anything, the Anandpur Sahib Resolution [ASR] is more a call for confederalism than neo-federalism.

Overall, the centralization thesis is constructed upon a break between Nehruvian and post-Nehruvian rule, an image of the Nehruvian Congress as an 'Aristotelian party' dominating and undertaking political development. That this image, at least in Punjab, omits the manipulation, control, constitutional subversion and the 'fanatical secularism' of the Nehruvian Congress is a matter of no little significance.

Economic factors

A second set of explanations privilege the role of economic factors (Singh 1987) in precipitating the Punjab crisis. At one level there is a

detailed focus on the Green revolution which is said to have heightened class and caste antagonisms, especially between the predominantly 'capitalist' Jat Sikh farmers, on the one hand, and agricultural labourers and Hindu merchant capital, on the other. Behind the ASR demand, it is suggested, is an economic agenda shaped largely by the Sikh capitalist farmers who now dominate the Akali Dal. At another level, the emphasis is on the modernizing consequences of the Green revolution which is said to have ushered in a mass society by dislocating, atomizing and shattering traditional village Punjab. As a result, political institutions and structures have lagged behind rapid economic and social change (Jeffrey 1986).

Although economic explanations have a powerful appeal they have been criticized on a number of grounds. As Kohli (1990) has noted, agricultural modernization has not been confined exclusively to Punjab, with the neighbouring state of Haryana undergoing a similar transformation without the alleged disastrous implications. Moreover, economic explanations often simultaneously speak of Punjab's 'overdevelopment' *vis-à-vis* other states in the Indian Union and 'underdevelopment' in terms of structural constraints of the Green revolution (Brass 1991, p. 230). By most economic indicators Punjab outperforms other Indian states so that the argument for relative 'underdevelopment' – structural or otherwise – is extremely weak. In fact, the arguments of extreme economic determinists are internally inconsistent, since they tend to 'switch the ground from the argument that communal divisions reflect the basic caste/economic cleavages to the position that communal divisions supersede them through the exercise of class hegemony' (Brass 1991, p. 229).

Sikh ethno-nationalism

A third set of explanations is based around the idea of Sikh ethno-nationalism. The Sikh ethnic revival, it is argued, is both reactive and modern (Singh 1987). It is reactive to four types of discrimination perceived by the Sikh community in India since 1947: constitutional, economic, religious and cultural. It is modern in the sense that though much of its inspiration derives from historical achievements, the objective is to create a political unit in which the Sikh community has effective political power. Since the late 1970s this revival has centred on the ASR, and whereas some have argued that this revival is organic and indigenous (Bhullar *et al.* 1985), the Government of India has viewed it essentially as a product of the Sikh diaspora and external forces 'with a deep-rooted interest in the disintegration of India' (GOI 1984, p. 3).

Opponents of Sikh ethno-nationalism point to three obstacles in its use as a critical variable. First, they question the whole idea of

essentialist Sikh identity, suggesting that it is the product of nineteenth-century social engineering in which the identity was self-consciously constructed, forged and determined (McLeod 1989; Oberoi 1994). Second, the claims of Sikh ethno-nationalism – its homogeneity, appeal and cohesiveness – are contested with the existence of class, caste, sectarian and political cleavages within the community, even though empirically these divisions are of minor significance (cf. Nayer 1966; Brass 1991). Finally, because the idea of Sikh ethno-nationalism implies that it is opposite (the 'other'), it is difficult to accept the former's logic unless we first abandon the proposition that India is a secular democracy.

Despite these objections – objections which are more formal than real – a modified Sikh ethno-nationalist perspective provides a more valid point of departure for understanding the Punjab crisis than the other two approaches. Neither rationalist nor economic explanations can fully explain the self-evident irrationality of Sikh politics over the last decade, what Connor has called the psychological bond of a nation 'that joins a people, in the sub-conscious conviction of its members, from its all non-members in a most vital way' (Connor 1993, p. 377). A fully-fledged theory of Sikh ethno-nationalism is yet to be constructed but any such effort would need to examine the integration of the Sikh intelligentsia into the Indian state, the reactive and negative character of Sikh ethno-nationalism, and the cultural context in which it has waxed and waned. Central to the latter must be a critical evaluation of the nation and state-building project of the Indian state since 1947, and how these processes have sought to delegitimize, disarticulate and deform Sikh ethno-nationalism as a 'communal' residual legatee of colonialism. What has been absent from conventional expositions of Sikh ethno-nationalism therefore is its dialectical relationship with Indian nationalism. Indeed, these accounts have generally tended to view it in isolation or merely at the rhetorical level of the protagonists. Consequently, as conventional approaches largely treat the Indian state as unproblematic, a new orientation is required if the above analysis is to be taken on board.

India as an 'ethnic democracy', 'hegemonic control' and 'violent control'

An increasingly radical reassessment of the Indian state has begun to question whether political pluralism applies 'only to cultural groups that remain within the broadly defined Hindu fold but discriminates against non-Hindu minorities' (Brass 1990, p. 169). Such assessments highlight the apparent cultural homogeneity of Hinduism which often transcends linguistic and other barriers so that 'Hindus "speak the same language" even when they do not speak the same language'

(Gellner 1983, p. 109, n. 1). Embree (1990), in a perceptive study of religion and nationalism in modern India, has argued that after 1947 Hinduism became associated with national culture so much so that it was equated with the status of a 'civic religion'.

For other revisionists, Hinduism provides a form of pan-Indian ethnicity in which even Nehruvianism, was at best, a 'defensive strategy against communal conflict rather than a charter for secularisation of Indian society'. This strategy implicitly accommodated Hindu religious interests because in the early 1950s Nehru initiated a pattern in which the 'Indian state would respond positively to religious pressures, particularly those emanating from Hindu groups, but would keep a distance from communal parties and platforms' (Upadhyaya 1992, p. 828). Moreover, the ethnic basis of the Indian National Congress [INC] – rooted in revivalist Hinduism of the nineteenth century – has been especially hostile to the ethno-separatism of minorities. If India's ethnic minorities have often allied with the 'secular Congress', this is indicative of their predicament as minorities, who have exchanged defence of identity and community for political support, instead of being motivated by ideological considerations (Copley 1993, p. 53).

The recognition of the Hindu-non-Hindu distinction suggests that the experience of Indian democracy conforms neither to secularized majoritarianism (where the state encourages acculturation and assimilation but allows ethnic groups to maintain ethnicity in the private sphere, for example, USA) nor ethnically accommodative consociationalism (where ethnicity, along with individual rights, is recognized as the basis for the organization of the state which acts as an arbiter between ethnic groups, for example, Belgium). India, in contrast, would appear to resemble a third variant; namely, an 'ethnic democracy'. According to Smootha (1990), the leading theorist of the concept, ethnic democracies combine 'the extension of political and civil rights to individuals and certain collective rights to minorities with institutionalised dominance over the state by one of the ethnic groups' (p. 391). Whereas in some ethnic democracies the process of 'institutionalisation' is formal and explicit, in others it is informal and implicit. In India the 'institutionalisation of dominance' would appear to derive from unspoken assumptions about state secularism, the historical ascendancy of the INC, and the ever present threat of Hindu majoritarianism. Thus, though the minorities have asserted individual and collective rights, the recognition of these rights has been based on a tactical accommodation with hegemonic Hinduism.³

Although ethnic democracies share most features of liberal democracies for the inclusive ethnic group(s), their relationship with excluded, peripheral and marginal ethnic group(s) is more problematic. At the extreme end of the continuum they might resort to a strategy of 'violent control' in which the 'superior power of one segment

[dominant ethnic group] is mobilized to enforce stability by constraining the political actions and opportunities of another segment or segments [subordinate ethnic group/s]' (Lustic 1979, p. 328). In between there might be efforts to steer ethnic democracy towards a liberal democracy or practise brute majoritarianism and circumscribe the rights of peripheral marginal groups. In such a context, the main ethnic group(s) 'can effectively dominate another through its political, economic and ideological resources and can extract what it requires from the subordinated' (O'Leary and Arthur 1990, p. 9). In contrast to 'violent control', the latter has been termed 'hegemonic control' because 'it makes an overtly violent ethnic contest for state power either "unthinkable" or "unworkable" on the part of subordinated communities' (O'Leary and Arthur 1990, p. 9), and can sometimes coexist within liberal democracies. Thus, whereas 'violent control' resembles overt domination, suppression and open confrontation, 'hegemonic control' combines Gramscian (Joll 1977) elements of coercion with some degree of consent that often underpins political and administrative structures.⁴

In India the recognition of the Hindu-non-Hindu distinction would suggest that a form of ethnic democracy coexists alongside 'hegemonic control' and 'violent control' over non-Hindu minorities. Where non-Hindu minorities have constituted a majority in the federating unit, the operation of 'hegemonic control' has been exercised not only through the Hindu minority community (and other supporters and ethnic groups) in such a state, but also through the frequent use of residual powers by successive Union governments, the administrative structure ('official regime'), and the coercive power of the Indian state. 'Hegemonic control' in India therefore is based not only on majoritarianism common to situations of binary ethnic group conflict. Rather, it coexists within a framework of *de facto* ethnic democracy which extends constitutional rights to minorities but mitigates their *de jure* application through excessive use of residual controls and placation of dominant ethnic sentiment. Where ethnic groups have contested, often violently, the nature of 'hegemonic control', the Indian state has readily resorted to 'violent control' and has made such contests 'unthinkable' by the ideological, economic and political resources at its disposal, and 'unworkable' by its coercive practice. Punjab along with Kashmir provides a paradigm case for evaluating the use of 'hegemonic control' and 'violent control' by the Indian state.

'Hegemonic control', 'violent control' and the Punjab crisis since 1984

A view of India as an ethnic democracy in which 'hegemonic control' and 'violent control' are exercised over ethnic minorities necessarily requires a reassessment of the post-1947 period. Applied to Punjab it

calls for a re-evaluation of India's secularism, the Punjabi Suba movement and the instruments and resources used by the Indian state to manage post-1947 Sikh demands. Such a re-evaluation would require a careful examination of how Sikh demands have been processed and the pattern of agreement, non-implementation and negation that has characterized the centre's dealing with the Sikh leadership since 1947. It would also question the Punjab Congress' 'secularism' in which the interests of the dominant ethnic group conveniently intersected with delegitimizing Sikh nationalist aspirations as communal, sectarian and religious. Indeed, Congress's accommodation of 'secular' and 'nationalist' Sikhs was not so much a meeting of minds with Indian nationalism as a recognition of the realities of power in which such accommodation was always a form of 'encapsulation', 'cooption', and required 'ethnic negation' (Pettigrew 1975). Seen in this context, the ASR is the culmination of a continuous process of ethnic negation by Sikh political leaders, whether secular or traditional, rather than simply a claim to political power.

'Hegemonic control' in Punjab between 1947 and 1984 becomes meaningful if it is recognized that, despite the gradations within them, the Hindus and Sikhs of Punjab have held two overarching loyalties: to a pan-Indian nationalism and to a distinct and separate Sikh identity that retains its historic claims to sovereignty. Federalization (linguistic reorganization) proved an inadequate mechanism because it was, first, resisted by the then dominant ethnic group (Hindus) which promoted assimilation and integration of Sikhs and, second, when it was granted, under unique conditions, was qualified by a number of (territorial, economic and administrative) provisions that retained the involvement of the Union government. The main political institution through which 'hegemonic control' has been exercised is the Punjab Unit of the Congress Party which has historically accommodated Sikh political groups, provided they were prepared to forgo ethnic demands. Since 1967 the efforts of the Akali Dal to challenge 'hegemonic control' have led to a campaign for autonomy and the restructuring of Indian federalism that culminated in Operation Blue Star.

(i) Rajiv-Longowal Accord: re-establishing 'hegemonic control'

If Operation Blue Star was an open rebellion against 'hegemonic control', the first 'war for Khalistan' (Akbar 1985, p. 209), the signing of the Rajiv-Longowal Accord in July 1985 appeared to mark a dramatic breakthrough in resolving the Punjab problem. Completed against the backdrop of Mrs Gandhi's assassination, the election of Rajiv Gandhi as Congress-I leader, and the latter's landslide victory in the December 1984 national elections, it appeared to mark a new departure in regional policy. The territorial, economic and religious demands that

had fuelled the Sikh agitation before 1984, and were held to be non-negotiable by Mrs. Gandhi, seemed to be recognized by the Accord (Gill 1993). For the moderate Akali Dal (Longowal) [AD(L)], the Accord provided a return to democratic politics; for Rajiv Gandhi, it represented a dynamic initiative, a befitting start to a 'clean premier-ship'.

Yet in retrospect, the Accord far from marking a new departure in Punjab politics was more a continuation of the centre's policy, dating from the early 1950s, of symbolic agreements accompanied by non-implementation. Hastily formulated by Rajiv's advisers, the AD(L) party to the agreement was assiduously groomed by New Delhi along the familiar pattern of tactical concession of political power at the state level as a quid pro quo for deflection, diffusion and de-emphasis on ethnic demands (Kohli, ch. 12). As a wit has aptly put it, this effort was a continuation of a pattern in which 'secular' and (Indian) 'nationalist' Sikh leaders have been regularly 'hailed' by New Delhi only to be 'nailed' when they have served their purpose (Singh 1992 p. 991). That this role proved difficult for AD(L) and its main factional opponent, Akali Dal (Badal) [AD(B)], were soon to become apparent.⁵

The Barnala government which came to power in September 1985 rapidly disintegrated as Rajiv's commitment to the Accord waned and the Congress-I government at the centre reverted to interference in the AD(L) government for short-term political gains. Whereas the centre increasingly viewed the AD(L) administration in terms of containing militant terrorism, its capacity to do so was undermined by the reluctance of the centre to implement provisions of the Accord. The transfer of Chandigarh, scheduled for 26 January 1986, was first delayed, then postponed, and eventually suspended for an indefinite period. Other provisions in the Accord (see Table 1 below) were either nullified or produced outcomes incompatible with the original agreement. The ultimate reversal of policy was marked by Congress-I factional penetration of Barnala government from April 1986 onwards, the appointment of a highly partisan Congress-I governor (Ray) and the instalment of Julius Reberio as the Director General of Police with a wide remit to undertake anti-terrorist operations. The Barnala government was finally dismissed in May 1987 when President's Rule was imposed on the ground that there was 'chaos and anarchy' in Punjab. According to opposition parties, however, the measure was taken to improve Congress-I's weak position in the impending state elections in the adjoining state of Haryana which was directly affected by the provisions of the Accord.

Table 1. *Rajiv-Longowal Accord*

Issue	Agreement	Implementation up to November 1989
1. Anandpur Sahib Resolution (ASR)	Referred to Sarkaria Commission	Oct 1987. Commission report rejects ASR approach to Centre – state relations
2. Transfer of Chandigarh	To be transferred to Punjab by Jan 1986. Punjab to compensate Haryana with equivalent territory for new capital. Other territorial disputes to be settled by a commission	Three commissions (Matthew, Venkataramiah and Desai) fail to provide an agreement. Strong opposition in Haryana. July 1986, Union Government suspends transfer for an indefinite period
3. Sharing of Ravi-Beas Waters	A tribunal headed by a Supreme Court Judge to adjudicate. July 1985 consumption as baseline	May 1987 Eardi Tribunal reduces Punjab's July 1987 level while doubling Haryana's share
4. November 1984 Anti-Sikh Delhi riots	Referred to Mishra Commission	February 1987: Absolves Congress (I) of responsibility; placed guilt on Delhi police
5. Army deserters	To be rehabilitated and given gainful employment	August 1985: of 2,606 deserters, 900 had been rehabilitated
6. Political detainees	Release of political detainees and withdrawal of special powers	Limited release; May 1988, 59th Constitutional amendment – provides for emergency powers in Punjab
7. Religious autonomy	Enactment of an all-India gurdwaras' Act	Not enacted; May 1988: Religious Institutions (Prevention of Misuse) Ordinance

(ii) *From 'hegemonic control' to 'violent control', 1986–1994*

The destabilization of the Barnala government ushered in a distinct change in the centre's strategy of dealing with the Punjab problem. Whereas the concession of political power to the Akali administration had enabled it to act as buffer between the centre and Sikh militants – and take on the unpalatable task of prosecuting the latter – the imposition of 'violent control' concentrated coercive, administrative and judicial powers in the hands of the Union government. 'Violent control'

has characterized the policy of the Indian government since April 1986 and, despite the 1992 Punjab Legislative Assembly [PLA] elections, it has been perfected into a form of 'coercive politics' where minimal legitimacy is combined with ruthless prosecution of political opponents.

The imposition of President's Rule in May 1987 further signalled that coercive measures were to take priority over political bargaining in resolving the Punjab problem. First, the new administration, which was directly accountable to New Delhi, was instructed to pursue a ruthless anti-terrorist policy with the aim of eradicating terrorism. Second, the security apparatus in the state was reorganized. In addition to the central reserve police force, the border security force and the regular use of the army, the powers of the Punjab police were strengthened with the creation of new senior posts and mass recruitment at constable and special constable level. Third, anti-terrorist legislation – National Security Act (1980), Punjab Disturbed Areas Ordinance (1983), Terrorist Areas (Special Courts) Act (1984), and the Terrorist and Disruptive Activities (Prevention) Act (1985) – was rigorously enforced with official approval of a 'shoot to kill' policy where known offenders were apprehended. Fourth, counter-insurgency was given a high priority with the employment of irregular hit squads intended to infiltrate and liquidate terrorist groups. The new mood of determination was summarized by Reberio himself: to give a befitting reply to 'bullets with bullets'.

However, instead of containing terrorism, vigorous anti-terrorism exacerbated the Punjab crisis. The terrorist and state-terrorist killing rate rose sharply from 1,246 (1986) to 3,074 (1988) (*Kessing's Contemporary Archives* 1988). Police encounters, moreover, politically disarmed the policy as the regular killing of innocent individuals touched a raw nerve in the violent culture of rural Punjab. Increasingly the anti-terrorist machinery resembled a non-accountable police state whose regular pronouncements that the end of terrorism was imminent were treated with incredulity by professional observers. In the event, even Reberio confessed failure. Terrorism in Punjab, he admitted, could not be eliminated by anti-terrorism. Above all, it required a 'political solution'.

More seriously, the anti-terrorist policy had a profound impact on the course of Sikh politics. Within the short space of two years the moderates in the AD(L) were sidelined by the emergence of a more radical leadership under Akali Dal (Mann) [AD(M)] which forged close links with the armed militants. The latter were further divided into two wings: the 'democratic militants' (who espoused the twin strategy of parliamentarism and the armed struggle for a separate state of Khalistan) and the 'armed ultras' (who consistently pursued the armed struggle for Khalistan and condemned the use of parliamentarism even as a tactic) (Singh 1992). Rejecting the Rajiv-Longowal

Accord, the AD(M) quickly established control over the institutions and structures of Sikh politics. The centre's deliberate actions to disarm this development by dividing Sikh militants backfired spectacularly, culminating in Operation Black Thunder on the Golden Temple in May 1988. Bereft of policy the centre adopted the 59th Constitutional Amendment which extended the period of President's Rule in Punjab for three years and included a provision for the declaration of a state of emergency.

Despite the removal of the Congress-I Union government after the November 1989 Lok Sabha elections, the National Front administration was unable to abandon the strategy of 'violent control' even though it was committed to pursuing a principled solution. The elections to the thirteen Lok Sabha constituencies in Punjab provided a landslide for AD(M) which increasingly used the language of 'Azad [independent] Sikh Raj' and, faced with a possible 'Latvian scenario', the National Front leadership acquiesced in the continuation of President's Rule while hoping that anti-terrorism would fill the void between policy and reality.

Ironically, it was the minority Janata Dal (Secular) government led by Chandra Shekhar which replaced the National Front that sought to abandon 'violent control' for the traditional policy of 'hegemonic control'. By trading the removal of President's Rule and the holding of PLA elections for promises from Sikh radicals and militants that they would not convert the elections into a 'referendum' on Khalistan, the Shekhar administration attempted to accentuate the disjunction between the claims for political power among Sikh political leaders and their ethnic demands. However, as the campaign for these elections progressed, the Congress-I's decision to boycott the poll further heightened these divisions as the elections became a contest between Sikh political groups. Despite the killing of twenty-four candidates, the Election Commission insisted that the elections would be held. As the results of the national all-India elections became available, with a clear indication that Congress-I would form the next government at the centre, the Chief Election Commissioner, after talks with the new Congress-I leadership, postponed the PLA elections on the eve of polling. He justified his actions, formally, by insisting that the increasing level of violence had impelled him to make his unprecedented decision; informally, it was generally assumed that 'the Chief Election Commissioner had bent backwards to please his new masters' (*Indian Express*, 23 June 1991).

The election of Congress-I central government in June 1991 led to the return of a forceful policy of 'violent control'. Elections to the PLA were not only postponed but were further put back until February 1992 with an extension of President's Rule. Administrative and personnel changes undertaken by the non-Congress governments were

reversed with the dramatic return of Police Chief, K.P.S. Gill. In November nine divisions of the Indian army were sent to 'pacify Punjab' and provide support for the forthcoming elections. Against these developments the Sikh leaders made common cause against the new central government and, at a conclave in Anandpur in September, decided to boycott any future assembly polls on the ground that the central government could not guarantee that such elections would be 'free and fair' (Singh 1992).

Faced with another extension of President's Rule, a perilous minority status (which could be improved by garnering thirteen Lok Sabha seats from Punjab), and the prospects of a complete election boycott by leading Sikh parties, the central government insisted on holding PLA elections without any prior settlement of outstanding issues in the Rajiv-Longowal Accord. In the event this 'exercise in democracy' led to significant breaches in election practices, required the presence of 250,000 army, paramilitary and police personnel, and produced one of the lowest assembly turnouts in Indian election history (24.3 per cent). The main beneficiary of the elections was Congress-I which won eighty-seven of the 117 seats in the PLA and twelve of the thirteen Lok Sabha seats (Singh 1992). While most of the electorate stayed away, the Congress-I 'won the battle for the state legislature but lost the war for Sikh hearts' (*India Today*, 15 March 1992).

Far from providing a radical departure the new Congress-I state government led by Beant Singh gave a weak form of legitimacy to the policy of 'violent control'. Faced with sustained opposition from the Akalis and militants it proceeded to coerce the former, while giving a virtual free hand to the security forces against the latter. The activities of moderate Akalis have effectively been outlawed with leading figures implicated in scandals and criminal cases. All major and minor mobilizations by the Akalis since February 1992 have been frustrated by stern police and paramilitary action in the name of preserving 'law-and-order'. Even by the most impartial accounts, if the 1992 elections restored the 'democratic process' in Punjab, this restoration has been mainly confined to the Congress-I.

The one notable achievement that the Beant Singh administration has claimed is the containment and elimination of some of the leading militant groups. From May 1992 onwards, bolstered by the assurance that the new administration would back anti-terrorist policies, the coercive power of the security forces was unleashed with unremitting vigour against militant organizations. This decision, which initiated the more pro-active anti-terrorism, led to some celebrated cases of state terrorism. The killing rate reached new heights with almost 4,000 dead by the end of 1992. Significantly, however, more terrorists were now eliminated than civilians or security personnel (*India Today*, 15 April 1993). These included some leading militants such as the heads of

Babbar Khalsa International [BKI] and Khalistan Liberation Force [KLF]. In 1993 more leading militants were eliminated with the killing of Bhindranwala Tiger Force [BTF]'s chief and the arrest of Dr. Sohan Singh.

While the Congress-I state government has been relatively successful in containing terrorism, the method by which 'normalcy' has been restored in Punjab is unlikely to provide an enduring solution. As an acute observer has noted, the application of the 'Punjab model' elsewhere in India could lead to 'the collapse of democracy as witnessed in Sri Lanka in the 1980s' (Joshi 1993, p. 28). The stability of the Beant Singh government, despite increasing support through patronage, municipal and *panchayati* (local) elections, can only be maintained by a high degree of 'violent control' and regulation which includes the denial of basic political rights to Akalis. Consequently, the elimination of Sikh militants has neither 'pacified' Punjab nor ensured that the Punjab problem will be adequately dealt with in the medium term.

(iii) *From 'violent control' to 'hegemonic control': prospects for the future*

In a way the strategy of 'violent control' pursued by successive Union governments since 1986 has had one primary objective: to restructure Sikh politics within the framework of 'hegemonic control' that has characterized the pattern of Punjab politics since 1947. Sikh ethno-nationalism which underpinned the politics of the radicals and militants has been intellectually disabused and now stands physically smashed. The limited resources available for Sikh nation-building and the experience of the militant movement suggests that as far as Sikh politics are concerned a return to 'hegemonic control' now appears to be the only realistic strategy available. In the short term, however, this return is unlikely because of the ideological and political investment by the Punjab Congress-I (and the national Congress-I) in 'violent control'. In the medium term, on the other hand, such return cannot be ruled out because of possible changes with the Punjab and national Congress-I, the election of a non-Congress-I Union government, and factional competitiveness among Sikh political groups that has historically lubricated 'hegemonic control'.

Of probably greater importance to Sikh political groups contemplating a return to 'hegemonic control' is whether the coercive power of the Indian state has once and for all exorcized the ghost of Sikh ethno-nationalism. If the statements of these groups are examined, however, they hardly provide an answer in the affirmative, couched as they are in traditional ambiguity and equivocation. Such conditions could encourage a return to 'cooption', 'accommodation' and 'encapsulation' familiar to 'hegemonic control'; they could equally lead to the

development of a more pacific and horizontal Sikh ethno-nationalism. Paradoxically, the Indian state might have successfully restructured Sikh politics but the consequences of such a process could be the opposite of what was intended.

Finally, it is necessary to ask whether 'hegemonic control' over Sikh politics can provide a form of relatively stable ethnic conflict management by the Indian state. The period between 1947 and 1984 (and 1985 and 1986) suggests that this is possible and has been facilitated by internecine factionalism among the Sikh political leadership, the absence of structured elite predominance, and minority status. Nevertheless, for reasons noted above, the collapse into 'violent control' after 1986 is likely to seriously qualify any future return to 'hegemonic control'.

In Punjab and other states (for example, Kashmir), the exercise of 'hegemonic control' raises fundamental issues: whether India's ethnic democracy is likely to develop towards a traditional liberal democracy where the institutionalized predominance of the majority is gradually eroded, or move towards a more cohesive ethnic core around Hinduism where ethnic minorities would be coercively assimilated. Since revisionists have asserted that the idea of Indian democracy as secularized majoritarianism is untenable, one alternative to ethnic democracy and 'hegemonic' and 'violent control' over minorities is the serious consideration of consociationalism where the state acts as an arbiter between ethnic groups. While at all-India level consociationalism would be difficult to implement, at state level there is a history of consociational practices that have been neglected or were destabilized by the 'Congress System'. In Punjab the gap between Sikh politics under 'hegemonic control' and the aspirations of Sikh ethno-nationalism might be better bridged by going 'back to the future' (Talbot 1994) rather than individualized indeterminacy of postmodernism (and the ever present ethnic Leviathan), or a dogmatic belief that India's democracy can create a new Nehruvian 'Congress System'.

Conclusion

This article has argued that traditional explanations of the Punjab crisis are increasingly irrelevant as we examine the developments in Punjab since 1984. The mainspring of the crisis arises from Sikh ethno-nationalism, the disjunction between its political reality and cultural and religious individuality that asserts claims to sovereignty. The political context within which Sikh ethno-nationalism has developed has been relatively neglected and requires basic appraisal of how the Indian state has managed ethnic conflict in Punjab since 1947. The main form of management has been hegemonic control which has sought to

delegitimize the claims of Sikh ethno-nationalism and make a contest for parallel state power 'unthinkable' or 'unworkable'.

After the failure of the Rajiv Gandhi administration to re-establish 'hegemonic control', 'violent control' was adopted as the main strategy for managing Sikh politics. Although the success of this policy under State Congress-I government since 1992 in physically eliminating terrorism has been notable, it is doubtful whether this achievement – and the methods used to realize it – can provide a return to status quo ante 1984. If anything, the contradiction within Sikh ethno-nationalism, and its management by the Indian state, require a new political settlement which should deal as much with the crisis of the Indian political system and how it has managed its minorities since 1947.

Notes

1. This figure is an estimate which includes the total number of deaths for 1993 and the anti-Sikh riots in Delhi in 1984. A total of 25,000 deaths in Punjab alone has been acknowledged by the Punjab Police Chief K.P.S. Gill, see *India Today*, 15 April and 15 June 1993.
2. The paradox of decentralizing a highly centralized state structure amidst intense ethnic conflicts has hardly been addressed in the Indian case. It can perhaps be argued that the case of the former Soviet Union and Eastern European states suggests that further centralization rather than decentralization is required to keep the state structure intact.
3. Reassessing the relationship between the main cultural force in Indian society – Hinduism – and politics, Embree (1990) has called for a critical appraisal of nineteenth-century German hermeneutics which celebrated the idea of Hindu tolerance embedded in the assertion that there are many levels of truth. 'What follows from this assertion', observes Embree, 'is not toleration; rather, all truths, all social practices, can be encapsulated within the society as long as there is willingness to accept the premise on which encapsulation is based' (p. 20). In the post-1947 period, this encapsulation has taken the form of 'theological secularism' which asserts that 'all religions are true' (in the name of secular polity), thereby reasserting the primacy of the Hindu universe which negates the exclusivity or externality of other religions.
4. Lustic (1979) developed the concept of 'violent control' in contrast to the consociational model. 'Hegemonic control' as used by O'Leary and Arthur (1990), however, refers to situations of majoritarian rule where the formal structures of liberal democracy are subverted for 'control' tempered with 'hegemony'.
5. Sant Longowal paid for this role with his life. S.S. Dhanoa, Chief Secretary Punjab, 1984–85, narrates an important incident which highlights the problem for Sikh political leaders in reconciling Sikh ethno-nationalism with the requirements of the Indian state. 'I had gone to see Sant Longowal,' he has noted, 'mainly to find out what was in store for us next in Punjab . . . I asked him why he was giving speeches which appeared to be inflammatory. He disarmed me completely by saying that if he did not speak that language people would not permit him to go to the rostrum . . . The initial response of the Sant only underlines the strength of the [Sikh] "stereotype" that a person of his standing perceived. He wished somehow to manipulate it and not face it directly' (*The Tribune*, 26 May 1992).

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